Natasha 2: Faster Non-Convex Optimization Than SGD

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NeurIPS 2018

List item 53 / Ref 81 | Tags: S, E, G / F, B | Tier: Must read

The paper in one minute

Question: Can an online stochastic algorithm reach approximate local minima with a better accuracy exponent than classical SGD?
Model/Method: Natasha 2 alternates between Oja-based negative-curvature steps near saddles and a variance-controlled Natasha 1.5 subroutine in regions with bounded negative curvature.
Finding: Under smoothness and stochastic-oracle assumptions, the method reaches (ε, δ) second-order stationarity with $\widetilde{O}(\delta^{-5} + \delta^{-1}\varepsilon^{-3} + \varepsilon^{-13/4})$ gradient complexity.
Why we care: It uses *how nonconvex a region is* to adapt optimization effort, separating saddle-escape and low-curvature stationary-point search.

1. Why ordinary stochastic descent wastes effort

For an online objective $f(x) = \mathbb{E}_i[f_i(x)]$, one stochastic gradient is cheaper than a full gradient, but noisy steps can require approximately ε^{-4} oracle calls for an ε-first-order target. Worse, an almost-zero gradient can indicate a saddle. Natasha 2 splits the job into two situations: when the Hessian has significantly negative eigenvalues, take a curvature-aware escape step; otherwise exploit a region where negative curvature is small to speed up stochastic optimization.

The two tests at a candidate point

$$\|\nabla f(x)\| \le \varepsilon, \qquad \lambda_{\min}(\nabla^2 f(x)) \ge -\delta.$$

A bound on the smallest Hessian eigenvalue is not convexity of the whole objective. It means the region is *almost convex to tolerance* δ; a positive training loss may still remain.

Worked curvature example: a "safe" neighborhood

Let $f(u, v) = \frac{1}{4}u^4 - \frac{1}{2}u^2 + \frac{1}{2}v^2$. At $(0, 0)$,

$$\nabla f = (0, 0), \quad H(0) = \begin{pmatrix} -1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

This is an exact saddle: moving in the u direction lowers the loss. At $u = 0.6, v = 0$, the Hessian is $\mathrm{diag}(3u^2 - 1, 1) = \mathrm{diag}(0.08, 1)$, locally positive definite. A detector that verifies $H \succeq -\sigma I$ near a reference point can justify using a routine tailored to bounded negative curvature. This toy function illustrates the curvature distinction, not the complete Natasha 2 algorithm.

A useful shift of viewpoint: You do not need to search for an escape direction at *every* point. You need curvature intervention when sufficiently negative curvature is present; elsewhere, exploit the more favorable geometry.

2. Natasha 2's two-stage design

Stage A: Oja's negative-curvature search

A stochastic eigenvector routine estimates a direction with negative Hessian quadratic form when one exists, then uses it to reduce the objective. It is the means by which Natasha 2 "swings by" saddle regions. The analysis accounts for the stochastic-oracle cost and Hessian smoothness, not merely exact matrix eigenanalysis.

Stage B: Natasha 1.5 exploits bounded nonconvexity

When $\nabla^2 f \succeq -\sigma I$ on a controlled neighborhood, adding a proximal quadratic can make the local model better behaved. A representative regularized surrogate around $\widehat{x}$ is

$$F_{\widehat{x}}(x) = f(x) + \sigma\|x - \widehat{x}\|^2, \quad \nabla^2 F_{\widehat{x}} = \nabla^2 f + 2\sigma I \succeq \sigma I.$$

This calculation applies *where the Hessian lower bound holds*; it is not a claim that F is globally strongly convex. The algorithm uses a stochastic variance-reduced construction related to Natasha 1, with minibatch snapshots and retraction terms.

What the complexity really says

The introduction states the (ε, δ)-stationarity complexity

$$\widetilde{O}\big(\delta^{-5} + (\delta\varepsilon^3)^{-1} + \varepsilon^{-13/4}\big).$$

Taking $\delta \geq \varepsilon^{1/4}$ yields an overall $\widetilde{O}(\varepsilon^{-13/4})$ upper bound after choosing the internal curvature resolution appropriately. Compare the accuracy exponent $13/4 = 3.25$ with the classical SGD benchmark 4; the gain is *in oracle complexity*, not a guarantee of faster wall-clock training on every network.

> **Read:** Sections 1.2 and 3–4, especially the informal Theorems 1–2, Figure 2 (negative curvature versus safe zone), and the assumptions near the formal results. Skim technical proof details unless citing constants.

3. Main findings and qualifications

Contributions. An online algorithm that combines curvature escape with a fast almost-convex-region optimizer; Natasha 1.5's bounds adapt to a lower bound on negative curvature; a formal improvement of the accuracy exponent in stochastic second-order stationary-point finding. **Assumptions.** A lower-bounded sufficiently smooth expectation objective, Lipschitz gradients and Hessian, and controlled stochastic-gradient/oracle moments and noise. Step sizes and confidence parameters depend on the desired first- and second-order tolerances. Refer to Assumptions (A1), (A2), and (A4) for the precise theorem version. **Limitations.** This remains a multi-stage theoretical procedure with nontrivial curvature-detection overhead. It finds an *approximate second-order stationary point*, not a global minimum; practical efficiency is not directly implied by the asymptotic exponents. The initially described algorithm uses a curvature/eigenvector primitive, later gradient-only conversions being separate work.

Connections to escape and variance reduction

NEON2 (Ref 77) offers a way of replacing curvature-oracle components using gradient information. **Daneshmand (2018)** uses stochastic gradient alignment (CNC) instead of deliberate curvature detection. **SSRGD (Ref 83)** later aims for a much simpler perturbation-based second-order guarantee with recursive gradients. **SpiderBoost (Ref 80)** concerns efficient *first-order* variance reduction without a full saddle-escape theorem.

Quick reference

Idea	Meaning
$\nabla^2 f \succeq -\sigma I$	Local bound on the severity of negative curvature.
Oja routine	Stochastic approximate negative-eigenvector search.
Natasha 1.5	Localized variance-controlled stationary-point subroutine.
$\widetilde{O}(\varepsilon^{-13/4})$	Accuracy dependence for specified δ regime; not seconds.
(ε, δ) point	Small gradient and Hessian eigenvalues at least $-\delta$.

Papers Master note

Allen-Zhu's Natasha 2 combines stochastic negative-curvature detection (Oja) with Natasha 1.5 in nearly convex regions, achieving a $\widetilde{O}(\varepsilon^{-3.25})$ stochastic-gradient dependence in a specified curvature-accuracy regime. The conclusion is approximate second-order stationarity, not global recovery.

Verified source: original NeurIPS 2018 PDF, Sections 1.2, 3–4, informal Theorems 1–2, Figure 2.